I’m not going to sugar-coat this: the video moved those people, but hardly one of them knew how to follow his gut and add his voice to the chorus of natural outrage that decency demanded. The nightly news was immoral. They had Wolf Blitzer on CNN talking to some female anchor, with her saying war was dangerous and that’s it. They showed the first part of the video and then blotted out the film once the bullets were fired, out of respect to the families. Nice touch. Shame about the Iraqi families. Fox News, of course, made it sound like the US military were owed an apology.

We would come and go with the American media over the coming year, especially, of course, with the *New York Times*, but it was difficult then and now to avoid the notion that a great many of them see themselves as holding a torch for what they perceive to be the American national interest. They want to put a curse on other people’s suffering, as if they had no right to expect sympathy in dangerous times. They will manipulate their own role so as always to seem pious and basically true to the flag. I don’t dislike America. I dislike what the present crop of political and media elite are doing to insult its best principles, its fine Constitution, and it will be our aim, as it is with other nations who behave as they do at their worst, to bust them.

Within a day of showing the ‘Collateral Murder’ video in Washington the backlash could be heard at all levels. And the attacks did not just come from the Pentagon. They came from people in the gutters of San Antonio to the former dreamers in the White House. Left- and right-wing commentators set out to crucify us for showing the world a video, a piece of military footage that might have made any self-respecting nation simply sad at the horrors capable of being enacted under its flag. There was no humility, no apology, no explanation even; just the rage of those who imagine that anybody who reveals the truth of such situations must be an enemy of the state. Such a poor and primitive response to journalistic truth, and shameful to the founding principles they pretend to cross the world to protect. Of course, they accused us of doctoring the video. Of editing it maliciously. Of erasing gunmen from the tape and making it seem worse than it was. It became surreal the way people would express with certainty all this nonsense. In fact, it was a military video given to us. All the angles were theirs, and the basic production values were theirs, and the acts committed were theirs, and I cannot imagine how they sleep at night while denying it.